

What we can answer, and what we'd need to ask for

Prepared 7 September 2026 by the Lunenburg Budget Project, an independent archive of the town and school budgets at lunenburgbudgetproject.org. Every figure quoted here is traceable to a document published on that site.

7 September 2026. Every answer below was tested against the documents we actually hold.

This is the plain-language version. It talks about **documents the town and the state publish**, because that is what an answer here ultimately rests on — not on anything about how we store them.

First: the one distinction that decides most of these answers

Four kinds of document, and they are not equally strong. Almost every "partly" below comes down to which one a figure came from.

1. The accounting system. The town's own books — every transaction, with what was budgeted, what was moved mid-year, what was spent, what is still committed. This is the strongest evidence there is.

We hold this for the schools for one year: FY2026, through 30 June. Plus one quarter of FY23, and the athletics revolving fund for three years.

2. The Town Accountant's year-end statements. The balance sheet and the schedule of special revenue funds, printed in each annual town report. Not the raw books, but prepared from them by the town's own accountant, and each one adds up to the totals it prints.

We hold thirteen years of these, and they are reliable.

3. The district's budget books. The school budget documents, which show next year's plan and also re-state what earlier years came to. That re-stated column is the district's own account of what it spent.

We hold twelve years. This is where most of our school spending history comes from — and it is the district describing itself, not an independent record.

4. The state's figures. DESE collects staffing, enrolment and spending from every district to its own definitions.

We hold seventeen years, FY2009–FY2025. This is independent in a way nothing else here is.

Why the third one keeps mattering. A budget book cannot show money being moved between lines during the year. Transfers get approved mid-year and never appear in it. So when the question is *did they spend it where they said they would* — that is precisely a question about mid-year movement, and only the accounting system records it.

Your three big objectives

ONE: WHY WAS THERE A SURPLUS, AND WHERE?

Which lines came in under plan — YES for FY2026, from the accounting system. That report shows, per account, what was budgeted, what was moved into or out of it during the year, and what was actually spent.

But "which lines" is not "what caused it", and I should not have let those run together. A line that came in under plan could be a post left vacant, a service that was cut, a grant that covered the cost instead, money moved to another line, or a line that was over-budgeted from the start. **Every one of those looks identical** — a smaller number in the spent column.

The accounting system narrows it: it shows mid-year transfers, so money moved to another line can be told apart from money not spent. That is genuinely more than a budget book gives you. It still cannot tell a vacancy from a cancelled service from a grant.

So: we can say **exactly where** the surplus sits, to the dollar, for FY2026. **Why** it sits there needs something else — the payroll detail for a vacancy, the grant records for a funding switch — and each of those is a separate request.

For FY2014–FY2025 — partly. We can show what the district *reports* it spent against what it planned, from its own budget books, for twelve years. That is worth having and it is not proof. It is their account of themselves.

What wasn't paid for that previously was paid — this is your strongest question and we can largely answer it. Twelve years of the district's own figures, line by line, shows every line that was funded and then wasn't, and when. It survives the weakness above, because it is a claim about what the district *reports* year on year — and their own book is a fair source for that.

Nothing has been built for it yet. It is the best page we could build next.

Where it gets harder: the district's line names don't map onto the town's accounting codes. The district names lines like *H.S. Guidance Counselor*; the town codes accounts by function. Nobody publishes the mapping between them, and we refuse to invent one.

And on their explanations: we can search everything the boards said from 2025 onward — about 1,400 documents. For anything earlier, we can measure what happened and cannot retrieve what was said about it at the time.

TWO: ARE THE SCHOOLS OVER-BUDGETING?

For FY2026 — yes, we can test it. The accounting system shows budget, mid-year movement and spending together.

Before FY2026 — no, not to a standard that would survive challenge. Both halves of the comparison come out of the same budget book. **A document cannot audit itself.** We can show a pattern in what the district reports, and we should — the same line coming in under plan eight years running is a budgeting practice, not an accident — but it must be labelled as their own reporting.

One thing to fix in how we ask it: *proposed* and *voted* are different numbers. Over-budgeting usually means "did they ask for more than they needed", which compares against what they **asked for**, not what town meeting approved.

All revenue for the whole town: for FY2026, yes, in full detail — every fee, permit and charge by department. For earlier years, partly: the annual reports list revenue by source, but some of those figures have been checked against the report's own totals and some have not, and the two cannot be added together.

Money outside the budget — yes, thirteen years, from the Town Accountant's schedules. That is already published on the site.

THREE: THE ALL-IN COST OF EACH LINE

No — and this one is structural rather than a gap in our archive.

A budget line is what the town has to **raise**, after grants, fees, state aid and the district's revolving funds have paid their share. It is not what the thing costs. To build an all-in cost you would need, for every line, the grants, the fees and the reimbursements that also paid for it — **and nobody publishes that mapping.**

The district's own budget workbook shows the problem: beside a transportation line, in the comments column, someone has asked whether that figure already reflects a reduction for expected bus fees. **The people writing the budget were not sure which of their own lines were net of what.**

What would close it: the state requires districts to file a year-end financial report that separates spending by funding source. That would give all-in cost **by category** — not line by line, but far better than nothing.

Your specific questions

How much on coaches, on athletic transportation, per year — partly, and I overstated this before. Six of the seven documents behind our athletics figures are budget documents. So we can say what the district *budgeted and reports* for thirteen years. What we have from the accounting system is the athletics **revolving fund** — three years of every transaction in and out. That is why we can say confidently what went into that fund and less confidently what the general fund paid out.

Have teacher counts changed — yes, seventeen years, from the state. Teaching staff has fallen from about 120 full-time-equivalent in 2009 to about 105 in 2025, while students placed outside the district rose from about 84 to 97 and total enrolment fell from 1,739 to 1,563. These are proper full-time-equivalent figures, not a count of names. **Nothing on the site says this yet.**

Has admin count changed — no. The state publishes administration *spending*, not administrator counts. The town prints staff lists by name in every annual report, fifteen years of them, but a list of names is not a staffing level: a part-time music teacher and a full-timer are one name each.

Grade-specific staffing trends — partly. The town's staff lists are per school, so you can separate primary from high school — but in names only. The state's full-time-equivalent figures have no grade breakdown. **You**

can have grade detail without FTE, or FTE without grade detail, and not both.

The special education paraprofessional question — much closer, not settled. Between 2018 and 2025 the district's reported spending on that line roughly doubled, while the state's count of paraprofessionals rose by about a third. **So more staff explains part of it and not all of it.**

It is not settled because the state counts *all* paraprofessionals and the budget line is special education only — different groups of people. And the remainder could be pay steps, more hours, reclassified roles, or a grant ending. The year-end financial report above would remove the grant explanation.

How many children leave the district each year — no. We have enrolment, which falls for many reasons: families moving away, smaller birth cohorts, school choice, charter schools. **A fall in enrolment is not a count of departures.** What would close it: the state's school choice and charter reports, which state how many children go where and what tuition follows them.

How many special education students — yes as a share, roughly as a count. The state publishes the percentage of students with disabilities each year: 14.7% in 2009, 15.8% in

1. Against current enrolment that is about 247 children — but that multiplication is

ours, not a published figure.

Separately, the annual reports give **out-of-district placements** for thirteen years, counted each 1 March and split into collaborative, day and residential. Those are children placed outside the district — a much smaller and different number.

Athletes and costs per sport — I said yes. That was wrong, and the correction is the most important one in this document.

We can show what the district's own athletics workbook **states** for each sport, for three years. We **cannot prove any of it**. There is no invoice, no payment record, and no independent figure to check a single sport against.

Three reasons, and the third is decisive.

The district has publicly disclaimed these numbers. School Committee minutes of 24 June 2026 record that community members "have asked straightforward questions regarding the actual cost of middle school athletics" and that "the answers have been inconsistent" — and that "available data suggests that user registration fees may exceed the known cost of operating these programs." When the people who produced a figure will not stand behind it, repeating it as established is not something we get to do.

The one independent record we have does not reconcile to it. We hold every transaction in and out of the athletics revolving fund for three years. In FY2024 that fund paid out \$317,004 and the general fund carried \$285,281, while the workbook states total cost of \$351,643. Those numbers do not add up to each other in any direction, and nothing published explains the difference.

And the payments do not say what they bought. Each disbursement from the fund carries a warrant number — 44 24 — and nothing else. **No vendor. No description. Not one mention of any sport in three years**

of transactions. So even with the ledger in hand, the money cannot be attributed to a sport.

What is actually established: how many participations each sport had, what fees were charged, and what the fund took in and paid out in total. **What is not:** what any individual sport costs. The honest answer to *"what does middle school athletics cost"* is the same one the district gave — nobody currently knows — and the difference is that we can now say precisely which document would settle it.

What would close it: the accounts-payable detail behind those warrants — the vendor and description for each payment — which the town's accounting system holds and does not publish.

The test I should have been applying all along

TJ, on the athletics answer: *"can we actually PROVE it? we have reports from the school, but can we match that to an actual invoice, or actual payment?"*

That is a sharper standard than the one I was using, and it is the right one for an audit. Three levels, and they are not close to equivalent:

1. **Somebody published a number.** A district workbook says a sport cost \$X.
2. **The number reconciles to something independent.** A second document, produced by somebody else or for another purpose, arrives at the same figure.
3. **The number is traceable to a payment.** An invoice, a warrant, a payroll record — the transaction that actually happened.

Almost everything in this project sits at level 1 or 2. Very little reaches level 3, and where it does not, the honest word is "stated", not "is".

Level 3 exists here for: the athletics revolving fund's transactions in and out (three years, though without saying what was bought), and the town's general fund for FY2026.

Where a figure has been publicly disclaimed by the body that produced it — as the athletics costs have been — it does not even hold level 1 securely. It is a claim somebody has withdrawn.

I will apply this test to the rest of the site. It is likely to move several answers downward, and that is the point of having it.

What I'd ask the Town for, given all this

Ranked by how much each would unlock:

1. **The year-end expense report from the accounting system, for the school department, for each year we want.** We already hold exactly this report for FY2026 — so we know it exists, we know what it looks like, and asking for prior years is a small request. **This single document turns the twelve-year over-budgeting question from "their account of themselves" into a real audit.**
 1. **The state's year-end financial report separating spending by funding source.** Closes the "is this line net of a grant" question that sits underneath the paraprofessional figures and the special education projection.
 1. **The school choice and charter sending reports.** Turns "enrolment fell" into "this many children left, and for where".
 1. **Staffing by budget line with full-time-equivalents.** Would let a dollar change be split into "more people" and "the same people paid more" — the question you asked and we still cannot fully answer.
 1. **The accounts-payable detail behind the athletics warrants** — vendor and description for each payment out of the revolving fund. Small, specific, and it is the only thing that would let anyone say what a sport actually costs. The district has said it does not know; this is the document that would tell them.
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Three pages worth building from what we already hold

1. **What stopped being funded** — every school line that went to zero or fell sharply, FY2014–FY2025, labelled as the district's own reporting.
2. **Teaching staff against out-of-district placements** — two state-published series, seventeen years, moving in opposite directions. Nothing says this.
3. **Which years are which** — a plain page showing which years of school spending we can evidence from the accounting system and which rest on the district's own account. Right now a reader has no way to tell, which is exactly how I got it wrong.